

CANADIAN CULTURE

Canadians often display their distinctive maple-leaf flag outside their homes. They are very proud of their country with its wide open spaces, lakes, mountains, and extensive national and provincial parks. But there is always the issue of US entertainment and culture flooding across the border and dominating the Canadian identity. To encourage Canada's own cultural development, the government gives grants to the arts, and the broadcasting, publishing, and film industries.



This Canadian "patriotic workshop" is painted in the colors of the country's flag.



GOOD NEIGHBORS

There has not been a war between the countries of North America for nearly 150 years. Recently, Canada, the US, and Mexico agreed to abolish trade barriers and open their markets to each other's exports. The full effects of this agreement are yet to be discovered, but Mexican workers like these farmers have already lost out, as cheaper US food and goods have flooded into Mexico. By contrast, cheaper food can benefit the poor.



This Mayan family is cooking tortillas.

NATIVE PEOPLES

Native Americans are the descendants of people who probably migrated from Asia via a land bridge across the Bering Strait about 20,000 years ago. Today, native peoples form only a small proportion of the population of the US and Canada. In the US, many Native Americans were moved onto special reservations in the 19th century as settlers took over their lands. In Mexico, native peoples, like these Maya, form about 30 percent of the population and are spread throughout the country.

This building in the city of Sacramento is home to the government of the state of California



EUROPEAN SETTLERS

Europeans have been settling in the US and Canada since the 16th century, but in the 19th century, immigrants began to flood in. They were often driven from Europe by economic hardship, political unrest, and religious persecution. North America was seen as a land of opportunity, where there was plenty of cheap land and people were promised freedom. The first immigrants settled on the east coast, but began to move northeast in the 1800s as industry began to grow.



State government		Federal government	
	Education		Foreign policy
	Highways		Currency
	Housing		Health care
	State police		National parks

In the US, local matters, such as police, hospital, and highway services, are taken care of by individual states. Matters that affect all the states, such as foreign policy, defense, and issuing currency, are dealt with centrally.

FEDERAL GOVERNMENTS

All three countries in North America have federal systems of government. This means that each country is divided into a number of states or provinces. These make their own local laws and also have representatives in the national government. Tension sometimes develops between the interests of the individual states or provinces and the interests of the country as a whole. In Canada, for example, a strong independence movement has grown up in the French-speaking province of Québec.